

Five state governments and various central ministries will have to work seamlessly to solve NCR's pollution issue. Otherwise, efforts remain fragmented

in construction activities. The government is also promoting e-vehicles and charging infrastructure under various schemes such as PM E-Drive. We are also adding 2,800 electric buses, migrating the intercity public transport to cleaner fuels and have banned entry of polluting commercial vehicles.

To address industrial pollution, the CPCB (Central Pollution Control Board) and SPCBs are closely monitoring red category and highly polluting industries through the Online Continuous Emission Monitoring Systems (OCEMS). In Delhi-NCR, 1,297 industries have installed OCEMS so far and connected it to the portals of CPCB/SPCBs. The CPCB is pursuing the others to instal OCEMS.

Q. How can India balance economic challenges with ecological concerns?

Economy and ecology have to co-exist. Infrastructure growth is important to meet the development aspirations of our people. Self-compliance and accountability as regards pollution control, abatement and prevention, strict vigilance and *jan bhagidari* (public participation) are crucial to achieving our goals.

complementing reference-grade stations. Independent annual audits must ensure sensors aren't hidden in green buffers to artificially lower AQI readings.

In 2020, the government set up a Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM) as a supra-regulator with powers to supersede states and penalise them. In practice, it relies on the very state governments it is supposed to be disciplining. It has no enforcement teeth—it can't seize vehicles, close brick kilns that do not use the zig-zag method of stacking because they operate at the city's periphery outside the government's jurisdiction or prosecute violators without the backing of state boards. The GRAP measures it lays down are reactive, their enforcement is entirely in others' hands. The central government granted the Commission its powers, but without any means of using them. For it to be effective, the CAQM has to be strengthened into a true enforcement agency with its own field force and the power to override state pollution boards. It should also be able to prosecute officials who fail to enforce clean-air rules, removing the political cover that currently enables inaction.

One could follow Beijing's arc to see how pollution can be tackled. In January 2013, China's capital endured a devastating 'Airpocalypse' similar to Delhi's, with PM2.5 levels touching 886. To combat it, China declared a sweeping 'war on pollution' in 2014, with Beijing basing the incentive system of its bureaucracy on environmental audits where falling short of targets could mean removal from office. The governance that followed—"scientific, precise, law-based"—produced striking results. As of 2023, Beijing had succeeded in reducing annual PM2.5 by more than 64 per cent, cut heavy-pollution days from 58 to a handful, shut down coal plants and reduced coal consumption by over 95 per cent; and imposed one of the world's most stringent vehicle quota systems that made the odds of obtaining a petrol car licence to a lowly 1 in 2,031. Simultaneously, Beijing added new lines to its subway system, taking the total to 27, making it the world's longest. To control stubble burning, the government prohibited open fires and provided incentives for converting 90 per cent of straw into fertiliser and energy.

A Chinese Lesson No One Wants

Delhi's policymakers say such harsh measures are not feasible in the capital. They have instead opted for a slew of techno-fixes, high on optics but low on outcomes. Smog towers, for instance, cut pollution by just 12-13 per cent within 100 metres. Anti-smog guns, which help in enclosed sites, are useless on open roads. The odd-even scheme, though politically catchy, offered only brief relief. "It was an eye-wash by Kejriwal, a ruse to spend Rs 20 crore on ads," alleges Sirsa. His government tried cloud seeding with IIT Kanpur, but it failed thrice this October due to low humidity. Now, the Delhi government has promised 18,000 EV charging points, 1,000 tonnes of additional C&D waste processing, complete biomining of landfills, a new waste-to-energy plant and 6.1 million new trees. All of them are on track to materialise by 2027-end, Sirsa insists.

The Centre, too, has thrown its weight behind the Delhi government's efforts. "After continuous meetings, we feel that a detailed plan for the next year should be prepared right now," Union environment minister Bhupender Yadav has said (*see interview*). "We have asked the Delhi government to prepare their complete plan for the next year."

But Delhi has never lacked a plan to clean its air, what it does not have is the will for implementation. The city was unable to spend even the meagre Rs 42.69 crore it was allotted under NCAP between 2019 and 2024, spending only about Rs 13.94 crore. The MCD was the worst spender of clean-air funds; it spent under 15 per cent of its allocated green kitty in 2023-24 and less than five per cent in 2024-25. Most of it was spent on mundane road-dust sprinkling and mechanical sweeping.

Yet, as C.K. Mishra points out, "No bureaucrat is ever penalised for not implementing pollution mitigation norms. And no one votes or even seeks votes in the name of clean air." And the harshest truth? Delhiites themselves resist change. "No one wants to leave their cars; or stop reconstruction of houses etc. You cannot clean Delhi's air without making some sacrifices." Are we ready for it? ■